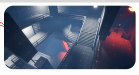
Featured Project

Youtube thumbnail



Escape Protocol

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Genre: Action-Adventure | Stealth
Type: Blockout
Engine: Unreal Engine 5.7
Tools: AGLS, Blueprint Visual Scripting
Iterations: 6+
Playtests: 12+
Role: Level Designer

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Escape Protocol is a single-player level built in Unreal Engine 5.7, designed around player choice, spatial exploration, and escalating tension. You play as a military officer trapped inside a prison under siege by a mafia gang attempting to free their boss. With helicopter extraction as your only way out, you must navigate through chaos managing health, gear, and enemies while finding your path to the helipad.

The level is built to support two distinct play styles. Players who prefer direct confrontation can fight through enemy encounters using the arsenal available throughout the level. Those who favour patience can slip through undetected using stealth and the environment to their advantage. Every major section offers both options the choice always belongs to the player.

The locomotion system used in this project is AGLS by LongmireLocomotion (Jakub Woś). All level design, spatial layout, encounter design, pacing, and environmental storytelling is original work.

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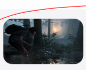
INSPIRATION & REFERENCES.

Games

The Last of Us Part I & II shaped the core combat philosophy of Escape Protocol stealth and aggression as equally valid approaches, with the environment providing opportunities for both. Player choice in every encounter was a direct design goal drawn from this.



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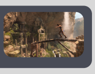
Tomb Raider influenced the exploration and traversal design. The sense of navigating a decaying, structurally compromised space finding hidden passages, using the environment to progress runs throughout the level, particularly in the cell block and collapsed sections.



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A Way Out provided the foundational reference for the prison setting itself its remote location, institutional architecture, and the feeling of being trapped inside a system designed to contain you.

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Until Dawn and Detroit: Become Human informed how narrative is delivered without cutscenes. Readable notes, environmental monologues, and object interactions carry the story forward the player uncovers the situation at their own pace.

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Film

Escape Plan and Die Hard provided atmospheric and tonal grounding one man navigating a hostile building under siege, managing limited resources, using the environment as both cover and route. Heat influenced the tactical weight of combat encounters, where positioning and patience matter as much as firepower.

DESIGN GOALS

The primary goal of Escape Protocol was to design a level that felt alive with player agency where no two play throughs would feel identical, and where every decision made by the player carried real consequence.

Five specific goals shaped every design decision:

Support Multiple Playstyles Without Forcing Either
Every encounter and traversal space is designed to support both stealth and combat. Players are never punished for choosing one over the other both paths are viable, challenging, and lead to the same destination.

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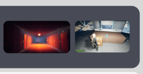
Use the Environment to Tell the Story
Instead of cutscenes or heavy dialogue, the level delivers narrative through environmental storytelling: readable notes, proximity-based monologues, lighting cues, and spatial composition. Players uncover what happened to the prison through exploration, not exposition.



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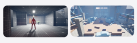
Build a Clear Escalation Curve
The level progresses from movement and exploration in Beat 1, to early combat in Beat 2, and finally to full tactical encounters by Beat 6. Each beat introduces a new layer of complexity while reinforcing what the player has already learned.



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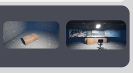
Reward Exploration Without Punishing Those Who Don't
Optional routes offer meaningful rewards, a silenced weapon, a sniper rifle, or tactical intel from security monitors. Explorers gain advantages, but players who push forward still progress. Curiosity is rewarded, never required.



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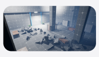
Create Genuine Tension Through Spatial Design
Tension comes from layout, not enemy count: tight corridors, darkness, broken navigation cues, and point-of-no-return moments. Difficulty emerges from uncertainty, limited resources, and the feeling that every choice matters.



LEVEL DESIGN DOCUMENT

This Level Design Document outlines the full design process behind my Prison Break level, including goals, blockouts, beats, encounters, and iteration. It highlights how I structure gameplay flow, communicate intent, and refine spaces through testing. The PDF provides maps, diagrams, and the complete breakdown of the final experience.

INSERT PDF FILE TO DOWNLOAD

TECHNIQUE HIGHLIGHTS

Technique Highlight 1:
Environmental Guidance Through Light

My Method: I used red emergency lighting as the primary navigation system throughout the level. Rather than waypoints or minimaps, the red light acts as a silent guide — players follow it instinctively without being told to.

How I Executed It: Red light is present at every key decision point and transition. In Beat 3 I deliberately removed the red light cue temporarily to create disorientation and tension. When it reappears, the relief the player feels reinforces how much they had come to rely on it.

Level Example: The notice board in Beat 1 explicitly states "Follow Red Light For Emergency Exit" — establishing the rule early so the rest of the level can use it without explanation.

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Technique Highlight 2: Risk vs Reward Path Design

My Method: Throughout the level, optional paths offer tangible rewards — better weapons, tactical information — but require more time, risk, or skill to access.

How I Executed It: In Beat 3, one landing path gives a silenced weapon enabling stealth but offers no progression. The other gives progression but no reward. In Beat 4, a dark room requires the player to navigate without light in exchange for a sniper rifle. In Beat 5, security monitors reward curious players with advance knowledge of escape routes.

Level Example: The silenced pistol vs progression split in Beat 3 is the clearest expression of this — the player chooses their playstyle through a single spatial decision.

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Technique Highlight 3: Escalating Combat Introduction

My Method: Combat is introduced gradually across beats — never overwhelming the player before they are ready, always giving them the tools before the threat.

How I Executed It: Beat 1 has zero combat. Beat 2 introduces a harmless enemy with a monologue prompt before the first real encounter. Weapon storage and practice dummies appear before the first gunfight. By Beat 6 the player is equipped and experienced enough for the level's most demanding encounters.

Level Example: The weapon storage room in Beat 2 — ammo, weapons, and practice dummies all placed before any real threat — ensures the player never feels thrown into combat unprepared.

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Technique Highlight 4: Environmental Storytelling Through Readable Objects

My Method: Narrative is delivered entirely through the environment — notes, fax documents, monologues, and spatial context — never through cutscenes or forced exposition.

How I Executed It: Two key notes carry the story. The first, found in Beat 2, establishes the threat: mafia gunmen sweeping the prison, stay quiet, stay alive. The second, a formal fax document found in the Beat 5 control room, reveals the extraction point for the first time — Tower 1 Helipad, last scheduled extraction, proceed without delay. Together they give the player all the narrative information they need at exactly the right moments.

Level Example: The fax document is the narrative turning point of the entire level. Up to that moment the player was surviving on instinct. After reading it they have a clear objective and a sense of urgency.

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Technique Highlight 5: Dual Path Climax

My Method: The final beat offers two genuinely different routes to the same extraction point — one favouring stealth, one favouring combat — both requiring skill and both delivering the same conclusion.

How I Executed It: The stealth path uses cover objects on the bridge, requires patience and crouch movement, and rewards players who maintained a quiet approach throughout. The combat path rewards players who built their arsenal across all previous beats. Neither path is easier — they are balanced differently for different playstyles.

Level Example: The annotated top-down map of Beat 6 shows both routes clearly — red for stealth, orange for combat — demonstrating the dual path design was intentional and planned.

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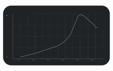
WALKTHROUGH

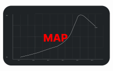
Pacing Graph

Every beat in Escape Protocol was designed with a deliberate intensity curve — starting slow to onboard the player and escalating steadily toward a high-stakes extraction. This graph maps that journey across all six beats.



Level Map — Top Down Overview

Escape Protocol is built across four towers arranged around a central courtyard. Tower 1 (top right) is where the player begins. The level flows through Tower 2 (top left), across the courtyard, into Tower 3 (bottom left), and finally up to Tower 1 (top right) where the helicopter awaits. The red dotted lines show the two available ground-level routes through the courtyard in Beat 6 — stealth through cover or direct combat. The green lines mark the zipline connecting Tower 4 to Tower 1, the final traversal before extraction.



THE NUMBERING IS JUST FOR YOUR UNDERSTANDING DONT PUT THEM ON WEBSITE

Beat 1 — Orientation
Tower 2 Interior | No Combat | Low Intensity

The level opens in a flickering red emergency light. The player is immediately blocked from going back — the entrance is collapsed behind them. A notice board ahead delivers the only explicit instruction of the entire level: follow the red light for emergency exit. From this point forward the red light becomes the player's silent guide.

The first section is entirely movement focused. Walk, run, jump, ledge grab, torch, crouch, crawl — each mechanic is introduced in sequence through the environment, each one required to progress. Two paths appear offering different movement approaches but leading to the same destination. A road block ends the beat, forcing the player to find an alternate route upward.

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Beat 2 — First Contact
Tower 2 Upper Floors | Stealth + Combat Introduction | Low → Medium Intensity

The player opens a door into a storage area and is forced to pick up a note. The message is urgent — the prison has been taken over, mafia gunmen are sweeping every block, stay alert and move quiet. This is the first narrative beat and the first time the player understands the full danger of their situation.

Exiting storage the player encounters the first enemy — harmless until approached, with a monologue prompt and a clear instruction to eliminate. After the takedown, a weapon storage room rewards the player with ammo, firearms, and practice dummies. Two path options appear before the first real combat — a pair of armed enemies guarding the upper floor. After clearing them the player discovers a blocked route, finds a way upward through ledge climbing, and the beat ends.

INSERT Youtube Video

Beat 3 — Into the Dark
Tower 2 Cell Block | Exploration + Traversal | Medium Intensity

Two landing choices greet the player — one path rewards with a silenced weapon, the other gives progression only. This is the first pure risk versus reward decision. Neither path is signposted — the player must explore to discover what each offers.

Tight spaces create genuine stress. A relief moment opens into a larger area with a visible exit nearby. Ladder climbing is introduced. The red light disappears — the player feels lost and uncertain. New pathways through the cell block eventually reveal red light traces again. The beat ends with the player back on track but having experienced real disorientation for the first time.

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Beat 4 — The World Opens
Tower 3 Office Floors | Escalating Combat + Discovery | Medium → High Intensity

A risky slide down a slanted platform opens Beat 4 with immediate physical stakes. Three path choices appear — one familiar blocked route from Beat 3, one reward only path with an AK-47, and one progression path. The environment shifts from prison cells to office space — the world of the prison is expanding.

A bridge connecting towers triggers a monologue and delivers the level's first full exterior view. Tower 1 and Tower 4 are visible and labelled — the player understands the full scale of the environment for the first time. Back inside the office, a dark room forces torch use and rewards with a sniper rifle. High tension followed by high reward — the beat ends with the player well-armed and moving forward.

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Beat 5 — Point of No Return
Tower 3 Control Room + Ground Floor | Puzzle + Narrative Climax | High Intensity

Red light returns, restoring player confidence. A large slant drops the player to ground level — the first time they have been at street level. A monologue confirms there is no direct way out. Exploration reveals a ledge climbing route with a new variation keeping traversal fresh.

The control room is the narrative heart of the level. A button opens a door remotely. Security monitors show escape platforms ahead — a visual reward for curious players who look closely. A fax document on the desk delivers the clearest objective of the entire level: Tower 1 Helipad, last scheduled extraction, proceed without delay. A monologue confirms there is no going back. An interactable object reveals a vent escape route. The player lands at ground level with the door open and enemies ahead. The final push begins.

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Beat 6 — Extraction
Ground Level + Tower 4 + Tower 1 | Final Combat + Dual Path Climax | High → Climax

A patrolling armed enemy greets the player at the exit — the most dangerous surprise encounter of the level. Stealth or combat, the choice is immediate and consequential.

Two routes to extraction exist from this point. The stealth path uses cover objects on a bridge, requires full crouch navigation, and demands one final elimination before reaching a zipline connecting Tower 4 to Tower 1. The combat path clears ground level aggressively, climbs toward the opposite bridge, eliminates one more enemy, and reaches the same final ladder. Both paths converge at the Tower 4 exterior climbing trail, leading to the rooftop. From there Tower 1 is visible. A final climb delivers the player to the helipad. Extraction complete.

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Process Breakdown I Playtest and Iterations

How the Level Was Built

Escape Protocol was developed across 6+ iterations, each driven by playtesting feedback and personal observation. The process followed a consistent loop — build, test, identify problems, solve, repeat.

Beat 1 — Movement Onboarding

Early playtests showed players frequently falling into gaps after standard walk-jumps. I redesigned the platform to teach movement progressively — introducing a short jump before a long jump, adding a runway for momentum, and placing an on-screen prompt before the larger gap.

Players still fell into the pit. Rather than removing the challenge I turned it into a teaching moment — adding ledge grab surfaces inside the pit so players discovered the mechanic naturally. From that point forward no further ledge indicators were needed.

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SLIDER EFFECT FOR THIS SECTION

Beat 2 — Narrative Timing + Enemy Layout

The narrative letter originally appeared after the first enemy encounter, disrupting the story flow. After testing I moved it before the encounter so players understood the situation before facing danger.

The first enemy was originally patrolling but the space was too tight for new players. I replaced him with a stationary guard and used narrative text to introduce stealth takedowns. Two patrolling gunmen on the same floor overwhelmed players — I introduced vertical separation, placing them on an upper floor with an ammunition room below. A rifle pickup made the encounter too easy so I removed it, limiting the player to a pistol. The hidden silenced pistol was being missed due to ledge placement — I redesigned the area to force exploration so players discovered it naturally.

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Beat 3 — Rifle Placement + Visual Cues

The rifle was originally placed immediately after Beat 2, breaking narrative urgency. I moved it later — after all traversal in Tower 2 was complete — and hid it in a chest near the bridge to Tower 3. Playtesters missed it due to darkness, so I added a red light cue to draw attention while still rewarding exploration.

This placement also strengthened narrative logic — the player receives a long-range weapon right before entering open ground where it becomes essential.

A key piece of playtest feedback shaped this beat directly: one tester could not find the silenced pistol because there was no ledge guiding them to that floor. The reward was being completely missed. I added the ledge, redesigned the approach, and the item became discoverable without being handed to the player.

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SLIDER EFFECT FOR THIS SECTION

Beat 4 — Arena Reveal + Sequence Control

Players discovered they could jump directly from the broken bridge into the final combat arena, skipping an entire beat and entering unprepared. I added blocking volumes to prevent this. To preserve the intended preview moment I added a triggered sequence showing the arena layout, enemy positions and scale before the player entered.

The sniper rifle on this floor was initially too hidden. I added a subtle red light cue — consistent with the lighting language established in Beat 1 — encouraging players to use their torch to find it.

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Beat 5 — Control Room + Traversal

The ledge climbing section was too similar to Beat 2 and felt repetitive. I added a central column blocking the vent from view, forcing players to explore the control room before finding the route. Players were confused about where to go after entering the arena, so I added CCTV monitors showing clear pathways ahead.

The narrative letter format was repeated from Beat 2, so I replaced it with a fax document — different format, stronger urgency, clearer objective. Players attempted to backtrack through the vent causing fall damage, so I added a monologue preventing backtracking and reduced the vent size to make it one-directional.

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SLIDER EFFECT FOR THIS SECTION

Final Beat — Enemy Tuning + Spatial Clarity

Two critical pieces of playtest feedback shaped the final beat.

First, the enemies were too difficult — players had to retry multiple times due to excessive enemy damage and health. I discovered enemies were using the same weapon stats as the player, making them disproportionately powerful. I reassigned their weapons to separate data slots and used the AGLS data table to reduce enemy damage and adjust health values. The final encounter became fair, challenging and satisfying.

Second, players outside could not identify which tower had the helipad. The fax document stated Tower 1 but all towers looked identical from ground level — players were moving aimlessly. I added large exterior tower labels — Tower 1, Tower 2, Tower 3, Tower 4 — visible from ground level and across the open yard. Immediately players oriented themselves correctly and the final push felt purposeful.

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Technical Challenges

Two significant technical problems were encountered during development.

The first was lighting management across indoor and outdoor spaces. Balancing the atmospheric red emergency lighting indoors against the natural daylight of the exterior environment required continuous iteration to maintain visual consistency and player readability across both contexts.

The second was working with AGLS — the Advanced Game Locomotion System. Documentation was limited and the system was complex. Key features required significant time to understand and implement correctly. One major gap was the absence of a health pickup system within AGLS — the system architecture made adding one prohibitively time-consuming.

Rather than spending development time solving a complex technical problem, I made a design decision: I restructured the level progression so that even a player with low combat skill would not lose health frequently. Enemy encounters were reduced in number, combat sequences were simplified, and the focus was placed firmly on level design, traversal, and pacing. This constraint ultimately strengthened the design — forcing clarity and intention in every encounter rather than relying on combat volume.

Reflection
Across playtesting, the level kept proving itself in small moments. In Beat 1, players found the hidden passage on their own — the closed stairs and the flashlight nearby were enough to guide them without a single prompt. After Beat 1, players naturally looked for an alternative route when the bridge was blocked, exactly as the design intended. By Beat 5, most testers climbed through the ledge sequence without hesitation — a sequence I had deliberately made more complex than anything before it, requiring camera movement and grabbing simultaneously. They figured it out because the earlier beats had already built that instinct in them.
That progression — players carrying skills forward without realising it — was the clearest sign the level was working as a whole.

What I Would Do Differently
Given more time, the first priority would be a proper health and inventory system. The absence of health pickups in AGLS forced a design workaround — structuring encounters so players rarely died rather than giving them tools to survive a harder fight. A full system would have opened the door to more competitive survival scenarios and richer resource management.
More time would also mean larger spaces. With that constraint removed, exploration sections could expand significantly — giving the narrative more room and rewarding thorough players with richer environmental storytelling.
PrisonBreak_LD is the foundation of something bigger. The core systems work. The next step is building on this prototype with the production features it needs to become a complete experience.